

ELECTED OFFICIAL BRIEFING

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Charlotte City Council | At-Large | Charlotte, NC

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1. EXECUTIVE SUMMARY

The Situation

You're stepping into your fifth At-Large term on a City Council facing its most consequential year in recent memory. Charlotte's 642,783 registered voters rank **affordable housing** (score: 66.4) and **public transit** (score: 64.7) as their top priorities — both areas where 2025 delivered major policy milestones your leadership helped shape: the unanimous FY2026 budget and the historic transit sales tax referendum passage. But the city also carries serious unfinished business into 2026: a federal safety audit citing 18 failures at CATS, a 9% CMPD officer vacancy rate, a looming FY2027 budget gap, and seven Community Area Plans still awaiting adoption. The broader political backdrop — federal funding threats, immigration enforcement tensions, and a Republican state legislature increasingly focused on Charlotte — adds urgency to every major decision this year.

Your First 90 Days: Top 4 Focus Areas

First, **lead CATS safety accountability**. As a Safety Committee member, you are positioned to demand transparent, public reporting on all 18 FTA corrective action items — preventing the city from repeating its mistake of approving a \$3.4M image campaign while safety failures festered. Constituents' transit priority score (64.7) means this issue directly connects to what they care about most. Second, **anchor the FY2027 budget around constituent priorities**. Use your Budget Committee seat to ensure affordable housing trust fund allocations and public safety staffing are the anchors of the FY2027 budget framework — not afterthoughts competing with a property tax increase narrative. Third, **drive the remaining seven Community Area Plans across the finish line**. Constituents' housing and anti-gentrification scores (66.4 and 62.0) show they care deeply about neighborhood-level development decisions. Sponsor targeted engagement in underrepresented North and East Charlotte communities. Fourth, **position Charlotte as a stable, welcoming, well-governed city** in the face of federal pressure. Your track record on immigrant community support and data-driven governance gives you credibility to lead this narrative publicly.

2. LESSONS LEARNED FROM RECENT HISTORY

1. Consent Agenda Approvals of Controversial Items Backfire Publicly

The City Council approved a \$3.4M CATS marketing contract on December 8–9, 2025 without floor debate — just two weeks after a second stabbing on a light rail car and one month before the FTA released its 18-violation audit report. Approving image spending without public deliberation while a safety crisis was unfolding triggered severe criticism from local media and residents. Scrutinize consent agendas carefully, particularly contracts tied to departments under active scrutiny.

2. Closed-Session Personnel Decisions Require Airtight Process

The \$305,000 settlement with former CMPD Chief Jennings — including a pension boost — was approved in a closed session through a procedurally contested vote. The NC State Auditor opened an investigation, council member Watlington called it 'unethical and immoral,' and the controversy consumed months of public attention. Any closed-session action with financial implications must have clear procedural documentation and majority support before being executed.

3. The Transit Referendum Showed That 5-Year Coalitions Win — and Narrow Margins Demand Strong Turnout Operations

The 1-cent transit sales tax passed 52.28%–47.72% — a margin of just 7,535 votes out of roughly 327,000 cast. Five years of cross-jurisdictional planning and advocacy produced a historic outcome, but almost didn't: a 5% swing would have defeated it. Future referenda on housing bonds or other major investments must plan mobilization to match the coalition building.

4. Council Member Accountability Gaps Are a Governance Vulnerability

Council member Tiawana Brown remained in office for nine months after a federal indictment for COVID relief fraud, ultimately pleading guilty in February 2026. Charlotte's city charter has no mechanism to remove or suspend a sitting council member facing federal criminal charges. This is a governance gap that consumed public confidence and media attention throughout 2025.

5. Public Safety Data Can Tell a Positive Story — But Requires Active Communication

CMPD reported a 21% drop in violent crime and 13% decline in homicides in 2025 — significant achievements. Yet the dominant public safety narrative in 2025–2026 was shaped by the CATS stabbing, the Jennings controversy, and immigration enforcement raids. Strong results must be actively and consistently communicated alongside accountability for failures, or the bad news dominates.

■ GOOD PARTY POLLING OPPORTUNITY

Issue: Transit Safety and CATS Confidence

Timing: March–April 2026, while FTA corrective action plans are being submitted

Key Questions:

- How safe do you feel riding Charlotte Area Transit System today vs. one year ago?
- Which specific safety improvements would most increase your confidence in CATS?
- Should the city prioritize hiring more transit security or improving lighting and station design?

Why This Matters: Constituent transit score is 64.7 (Strong), but the CATS safety crisis has shaken confidence. Polling shows whether riders want enforcement, design, or staffing — giving the Safety Committee a mandate for specific corrective action priorities. **Action:** Contact Good Party to set up a transit safety poll before the CATS corrective action plan deadline.

3. QUICK WINS

1 Lead Public CATS Safety Oversight Hearings

- As a Safety Committee member, introduce a motion requiring CATS to present monthly public progress reports on all 18 FTA corrective action items. Hold the first hearing in April 2026 with CATS leadership, FTA representatives, and the new MPTA board. This positions you as a lead accountability voice on constituents' #2 priority (transit, 64.7) while preventing a repeat of the \$3.4M image-over-safety controversy.

2 Secure Affordable Housing Trust Fund in FY2027 Budget Framework

- Use your Budget Committee seat to propose a floor commitment for the Housing Trust Fund in the FY2027 budget — ideally matching or exceeding FY2026 levels plus an inflation adjustment. Tie it to the new MPTA transit corridors: affordable housing near the Red Line and Silver Line stations addresses constituents' top two priorities simultaneously (housing 66.4, transit 64.7). Propose this in the April–May budget workshops before the City Manager's formal proposal.

3 Sponsor Community Engagement Events for the Seven Pending Area Plans

- The seven Community Area Plans tabled in November 2025 were delayed specifically due to insufficient engagement in North and East Charlotte — neighborhoods with historically lower political representation and higher concentrations of residents concerned about gentrification (score: 62.0). Co-host two to three town halls in targeted zip codes by May 2026 to bring these plans to a vote in the second half of the year.

4 Champion a Durable Immigrant Community Resilience Fund

- The \$100,000 emergency immigrant aid allocation in November 2025 was reactive and one-time. Propose converting this into a standing annual grant cycle — even \$250,000–\$500,000 annually — for immigrant-serving nonprofits covering legal aid, language access, and economic stabilization. Frame it as community resilience infrastructure, not immigration policy. This directly addresses constituent social services priority (60.5) and builds on your existing leadership on this issue.

5 Introduce a CMPD Recruitment and Retention Accountability Report

- Charlotte's 9% CMPD vacancy rate (≈300 officers) and the upcoming 6.5% pay raise proposal will dominate the FY2027 budget conversation. Request that the City Manager present a dedicated CMPD recruitment pipeline report — covering academy class sizes, lateral hire rates, and attrition reasons — before the May budget proposal. This arms the Budget Committee with specific data and shows proactive engagement on public safety without prejudging the tax rate question.

■ GOOD PARTY POLLING OPPORTUNITY

Issue: FY2027 Budget Priorities — Property Tax vs. Service Levels

Timing: April 2026, before the City Manager's May budget proposal

Key Questions:

- If the city must raise property taxes to fund 300 additional police officers, would you support that?
- Which city service would you most want protected if budget cuts are required?

- Should the city prioritize affordable housing spending, public safety staffing, or transit investment in FY2027?

Why This Matters: The property tax question is coming regardless. Polling gives Budget Committee members constituent-backed evidence for the tradeoffs — rather than letting the loudest voices in council chambers set the frame.

Action: Contact Good Party to run a budget priorities poll in April 2026.

4. YOUR CONSTITUENTS' TOP ISSUES

Data drawn from L2/Haystaq voter file for the City of Charlotte, North Carolina. Analysis covers 611,378 matched voter records. Scores are 0–100 predictive indexes; only issues within city council authority are included.

Demographics at a Glance

Metric	Value
Total Registered Voters	642,783
Average Age	46.0 years
Male	293,393 (45.6%)
Female	346,439 (53.9%)

Top Issues by Priority (Local/City Authority Only)

Rank	Issue	Score	Tier
1	Affordable Housing (Government Role)	66.4	Strong
2	Public Transit Support	64.7	Strong
3	School Funding (More Investment)	64.4	Strong
4	Climate / Environment Believer	64.1	Strong
5	Anti-Gentrification / Displacement	62.0	Strong
6	Social Services / Helping People	60.5	Strong
7	Environmental Policy Priority	56.2	Moderate
8	Infrastructure Investment	53.0	Moderate
9	Violent Crime Concern	51.2	Moderate
10	Economic Development Priority	49.9	Low

Tier guide: Critical 75+ | Strong 60–74 | Moderate 50–59 | Low <50. Federal issues excluded.

■ GOOD PARTY POLLING OPPORTUNITY

Issue: Housing Type and Anti-Displacement Preferences (Scores 66.4 & 62.0)

Timing: May 2026 — before Community Area Plans are re-introduced for a vote

Key Questions:

- Haystaq shows strong support for government housing action — but what type? Rent control, density bonuses, affordable unit mandates in new development?
- Which neighborhoods feel most at risk of displacement right now?
- Do you support allowing more multi-family housing near planned transit corridors?

Why This Matters: The 7 pending Community Area Plans will shape density and zoning. Polling provides constituent mandate for specific density and affordability requirements before those votes. **Action:** Contact Good Party to set up a housing and neighborhood poll in May 2026.

5. WHAT TO WATCH & PREPARE FOR

Issues Requiring Immediate Attention

- **CATS FTA Corrective Action Deadline (March–April 2026)** — CATS must submit corrective action plans for all 18 federal safety violations within 30 days of the February 2 FTA report, or risk losing federal transit funding. As a Safety Committee member, request a public briefing from CATS leadership on each item — do not allow this to be handled solely behind closed doors.
- **FY2027 Budget Workshops (April–June 2026)** — City Manager Jones will present the proposed FY2027 budget in May 2026. Budget Committee pre-work begins in April. A property tax increase for CMPD staffing is widely signaled — the council's position on scope and rate needs to be developed before the public proposal, not after.
- **Seven Pending Community Area Plans (2026)** — North Charlotte, East Charlotte (middle and outer), West Charlotte, and Northeast outer plans were delayed due to insufficient community engagement. These plans directly affect where affordable housing and transit-oriented development can be built. Constituent gentrification concern (62.0) makes these politically and substantively important to get right.

Political Dynamics to Understand

- **All-Democratic Council, But Not Monolithic** — All 12 council seats are held by Democrats following November 2025. But the Jennings settlement controversy revealed real fault lines: council members split publicly on process and transparency. An all-one-party council still requires active coalition management on individual issues.
- **State Legislature Oversight of Charlotte** — Republican legislators in Raleigh called Charlotte's mayor, city manager, and new CMPD chief to testify in February 2026 on crime and immigration. The NC Auditor is investigating the Jennings settlement. Legislative preemption on housing, transit governance, or immigration response is a real risk in 2026.
- **MPTA–City–County Governance Tensions** — The new 27-member MPTA board controls \$210M annually in new transit sales tax revenue. The MPTA chair and the city already disagree on the Gateway Station vision. Managing this relationship — ensuring the city's voice is heard without creating public conflict — requires careful navigation.

Upcoming Challenges & Decisions

- **Property Tax Increase Vote (June 2026)** — A property tax increase is widely anticipated in FY2027 to fund CMPD staffing and compensation. The current rate is 27.41 cents per \$100. Charlotte has raised it once in seven years. Constituent data shows violent crime worry at 51.2 (Moderate) — enough concern to support investment, but not an overwhelming mandate for large tax hikes.
- **CATS-to-MPTA Transition (Mid-2026)** — CATS employees, buses, and rail infrastructure must legally transfer to the MPTA, expected mid-2026. This is operationally complex and politically sensitive, particularly for CATS workers concerned about job security and benefits. The council retains oversight authority during the transition period.
- **Federal Funding Uncertainty (Ongoing)** — Charlotte's nonprofits, CMS federal grants for multilingual learners, and potentially CATS federal funding are all at risk from Trump administration policies. Courts have blocked some withholding attempts, but legal uncertainty will persist throughout 2026. The city needs contingency plans for each

major federal funding stream.

■ GOOD PARTY POLLING OPPORTUNITY

Issue: Property Tax and Public Safety Tradeoffs

Timing: April 2026, before formal budget proposal

Key Questions:

- Would you support a modest property tax increase (1–2 cents per \$100) specifically to hire 100 additional CMPD officers?
- What matters most to you: more police officers, better officer pay, or community violence prevention programs?

Why This Matters: Violent crime concern is 51.2 (Moderate) — split enough that council needs nuance, not just a blanket 'tough on crime' posture. Polling clarifies the specific mandate. **Action:** Contact Good Party for a public safety poll before the May budget proposal.

6. UNDERSTANDING THE ROLE OF CITY COUNCIL MEMBER

What Is Expected of This Role

Charlotte operates under a **council-manager system**, in use since 1929. The City Council is the legislative and policy-making body: it sets priorities, adopts the budget, passes ordinances, and appoints (and can remove) the City Manager. The 12-member council — Mayor plus 11 members — requires a majority of 6 non-mayoral votes on most items. As an At-Large member, you represent the entire city of Charlotte, not a specific geographic district, which both expands your mandate and requires citywide coalition-building.

Your Budget Committee and Safety Committee assignments give you direct influence over the two highest-stakes decisions of 2026: the FY2027 budget (property tax, CMPD staffing, housing) and CATS safety remediation. These are the right seats for your stated priorities and your constituents' top concerns.

What Is Outside the Scope of This Role

The City Manager — not the council — manages day-to-day city operations, hires department heads, and implements policy. Council members should not direct staff or intervene in operational decisions; doing so undermines the council-manager model and creates accountability problems. Charlotte-Mecklenburg Schools (CMS) is an independent agency governed by an elected school board — the city funds some youth programs and after-school care, but CMS curriculum, staffing, and school-level decisions are outside council authority. Federal immigration enforcement is also outside city council jurisdiction, though the council sets the policy framework (e.g., the \$100K emergency fund) for how the city responds to its community impacts.

How to Represent Your Community

As an At-Large member, your constituency is every Charlotte resident — not just those in organized advocacy groups or the neighborhoods with highest turnout. Haystaq data reveals what the broader electorate actually prioritizes: housing (66.4), transit (64.7), schools (64.4). Use this data to anchor decisions when vocal minorities push in different directions. Good Party's polling capability offers a direct tool to gauge constituent opinion on specific upcoming votes, giving you evidence-based constituent backing that public comment alone cannot provide.

7. TOP 3 BUDGET DISCUSSIONS (Sept 2025 – Mar 2026)

#1 — FY2027 Budget Workshops: Property Tax Increase Signaled for Public Safety | Feb. 2026 (Ongoing)

- Council members signaled in February 2026 budget workshops that a property tax increase is likely to fund CMPD staffing; current rate is **27.41 cents per \$100 assessed value** (WFAE, Feb. 23, 2026).
- CMPD has approximately **300 vacant officer positions** (9% vacancy rate); a **6.5% CMPD pay raise** and 3% raise for all other city staff are proposed.
- Final budget vote expected June 2026; City Manager's formal proposal arrives May 2026.

Outcome: No vote yet; workshops ongoing through spring 2026.

***Why This Matters for You:** As a Budget Committee member, you shape the framework before the public proposal. Establishing constituent-backed priorities now — housing trust fund, CMPD staffing, transit equity — prevents the tax increase debate from being reduced to a single public safety number.*

#2 — FY2026 Budget Adopted Unanimously — \$3.6 Billion, No Tax Increase | June 9, 2025

- Council adopted the **\$3.6 billion FY2026 budget** unanimously — a 5.2% increase from FY2025, with no property tax increase (City of Charlotte, June 2025).
- Eliminated **17 vacant positions** to offset a \$6.5M sales tax revenue shortfall; included full \$200,000 for Greater Enrichment Program (after-school care in Title I schools) (WCNC, June 2025).
- Included employee pay raises and record transportation infrastructure investment; ARPA one-time funds used for targeted adjustments.

Outcome: Unanimous adoption; budget took effect July 1, 2025.

***Why This Matters for You:** The FY2026 unanimous vote sets a high bar — and a pattern. The FY2027 property tax debate will be harder to achieve consensus on. Use your Budget Committee role to build consensus on priorities before the formal proposal, as was done successfully for FY2026.*

#3 — \$4.3 Million Startup Funding for New Transit Authority (MPTA) | Jan. 12, 2026

- Council voted unanimously to allocate **\$4.3 million** from existing sales tax revenue to help the new Metropolitan Public Transportation Authority get operational (WFAE, Jan. 12, 2026).
- MPTA will receive roughly **\$210 million per year** from the new 1-cent transit sales tax — approximately \$140M annually earmarked for rail (WCNC, Jan. 2026).
- Funds cover legal services, insurance, consultants, and administration for MPTA's first operating phase.

Outcome: Unanimous; MPTA operational with startup funding.

***Why This Matters for You:** This \$210M/year new revenue stream is the most significant new public investment Charlotte has seen in decades. Equity commitments — affordable fares, community hiring, equitable routing — must be embedded in MPTA's governance now, before operational patterns are set.*

8. TOP 3 NON-BUDGET POLICY DISCUSSIONS (Sept 2025 – Mar 2026)

#1 — Transit Sales Tax Referendum Approved — Historic \$19.4B, 30-Year Plan | Nov. 4, 2025 | Voter Vote: 52.28%–47.72%

- Voters approved a 1-cent sales tax increase for transportation by **52.28%–47.72%** — a margin of just 7,535 votes out of ~327,000 cast (WFAE, Nov. 4, 2025).
- Revenue allocation: **40% roads, 40% rail, 20% buses**; projected **\$19.4 billion over 30 years**; new rate: 8.25% (Axios Charlotte, Nov. 5, 2025).
- Priority projects: Red Line to Lake Norman, Silver Line (airport to Bojangles Coliseum), Gold Line streetcar extension, Lynx Blue Line extension to Pineville.

Outcome: Historic passage; MPTA constituted with 27 members; \$4.3M startup funding approved January 2026.

***Why This Matters for You:** Constituents' transit priority score is 64.7 (Strong) — this result reflects real demand. Your role now is ensuring the MPTA's equity commitments and CATS safety remediation move in parallel, so the investment translates into improved service that constituents actually trust and use.*

#2 — Federal Immigration Enforcement: Council Allocates \$100K Emergency Fund | Nov. 17–21, 2025 | Vote: Unanimous

- 'Operation Charlotte's Web' deployed CBP and ICE agents across Charlotte, resulting in **425+ arrests** and temporarily shutting down ~20% of CMS school attendance and many immigrant-owned businesses (WFAE, Nov. 17, 2025).
- Council voted unanimously Nov. 21 to commit **\$100,000 in emergency aid** for income-eligible households facing income loss; Crisis Assistance Ministry administered funds; partners included Charlotte Center for Legal Advocacy, Latin American Coalition, Carolina Migrant Network (WFAE, Nov. 21, 2025).
- Council member Ajmera publicly characterized the operation as politically motivated, linked to the 2026 NC Senate race.

Outcome: Unanimous; \$100K disbursed through Crisis Assistance Ministry.

***Why This Matters for You:** Constituents' social services priority (60.5) and your leadership on this issue create a natural opening to convert the reactive emergency fund into a durable annual grant cycle — making Charlotte's community resilience infrastructure a standing commitment rather than a crisis response.*

#3 — Seven Community Area Plans Adopted; Seven Tabled for More Engagement | Nov. 24, 2025

- Council adopted 7 of 14 Community Area Plans implementing the Charlotte Future 2040 Comprehensive Plan: **East Inner, Northeast Inner, South Inner, South Middle, South Outer, Southwest Middle, Southwest Outer** (Charlotte Future 2040).
- 7 plans tabled — covering **North, East Middle/Outer, West, and Northeast Middle/Outer Charlotte** — due to insufficient community engagement; these will return in 2026 (WCNC).
- Plans shape zoning, housing density, transit-oriented development, and affordable housing bonus programs at the neighborhood level.

Outcome: 7 plans adopted; 7 pending for 2026 with deeper engagement required.

***Why This Matters for You:** The pending plans cover neighborhoods with high gentrification concern and historically lower civic engagement. Leading targeted outreach in these areas before the vote converts a policy delay into a*

community trust-building opportunity — and delivers on constituents' housing and anti-displacement priorities (66.4 and 62.0).

9. APPENDIX: KEY RESOURCES

Resource	URL / Detail
City of Charlotte	charlottenc.gov
Council Member Directory	charlottenc.gov/City-Government/Leadership/City-Council
Dimple Ajmera Official Profile	charlottenc.gov/.../Dimple-Ajmera
Council Meeting Agendas (Past & Present)	charlottenc.gov/City-Government/Council-Meetings/Agendas-Past-Present
Upcoming Council Meetings	charlottenc.gov/City-Government/Council-Meetings/Upcoming-Meetings
LegiStar (Searchable votes & minutes)	charlottenc.legistar.com
Strategy & Budget Department	charlottenc.gov/City-Government/Departments/Strategy-Budget
FY2027 Budget Development	charlottenc.gov/.../Budget-Development
Council Video Archives	charlotte.cablecast.tv
Charlotte Future 2040 / Area Plans	cltfuture2040.com
CATS Transit	charlottenc.gov/CATS/Home
Mayor	Vi Lyles (5th term; inaugurated Nov. 2025)
City Manager	Marcus D. Jones (appointed 2016)
Strategy & Budget Director	Marie Harris
CMPD Police Chief	Estella Patterson (Charlotte's first female chief; sworn Dec. 5, 2025)
Deputy City Manager – Planning	Alyson Craig
Interim CATS Director	Brent Cagle
MPTA Board Chair	David Howard
Key Numbers	Value
FY2026 Total Budget	\$3.6 billion (adopted June 9, 2025)
Current Property Tax Rate	27.41 cents per \$100 assessed value
CMPD Officer Vacancy Rate	~9% (~300 vacancies)
Transit Sales Tax Annual Revenue	~\$210M/year to MPTA
New Transit Plan (30-year)	\$19.4 billion total

2025 Violent Crime Change	-21% year-over-year (CMPD)
2025 Homicide Change	-13% year-over-year (CMPD)

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